McNamara, and Maxwell Taylor. The Special Group Augmented (SGA) was chaired by Robert Kennedy, whose unhappiness with the lack of progress became increasingly apparent. The operation involved sabotage and subversion, including poisoning sugar exports, destroying oil refineries, blowing up railway bridges, and setting chemical plants ablaze. One inventive CIA operative described how he tied bags of inflammable material to the tails of unfortunate domestic cats to set fire to fields of sugar crops. Each cat could be expected to destroy two to three kilometres of crops.[83] There is also clear evidence that the Special Group was cognisant of CIA assassination planning against Castro.[84]

Operation Mongoose did not involve direct US military intervention. In March 1962, however, the Joint Chiefs of Staff were tasked by Robert Kennedy's group with providing pretexts to justify overt US intervention. Various ruses and provocations were suggested, including faking terrorist atrocities in the United States. One idea was a 'series of well-coordinated incidents' in and around the US naval base at Guantánamo to create the impression of attacks by Cuban forces. These would include riots, mortar attacks, blowing up ammunition dumps, sabotaging or sinking ships. In 1898 the sinking of the US battleship USS *Maine* and the deaths of 260 US sailors precipitated Washington's entry into the war with Spain. The circumstances of the explosion on the battleship remain unclear. When the French freighter, *La Coubre*, blew up in Havana harbour in 1960, Fidel Castro compared the event to the sinking of the *Maine* and claimed the US government had sunk their battleship in 1898 to provide a pretext for entering the war against Spain. Great minds think alike: the Joint Chiefs also wanted to 'Remember the Maine' and suggested blowing up an American ship in Guantánamo Bay and blaming Cuba. The USS *Maine* resurfaced – so to speak – during the missile crisis, when Robert Kennedy pressed for an invasion using a pretext involving Guantánamo: 'you know, sink the *Maine* again or something'.[85]

Covert action was, moreover, part of a broader and coordinated approach that included diplomatic isolation, economic sanctions, and military sabre-rattling. At Washington's instigation, Cuba was suspended from the Organisation of American States (OAS) in January 1962. In February, all